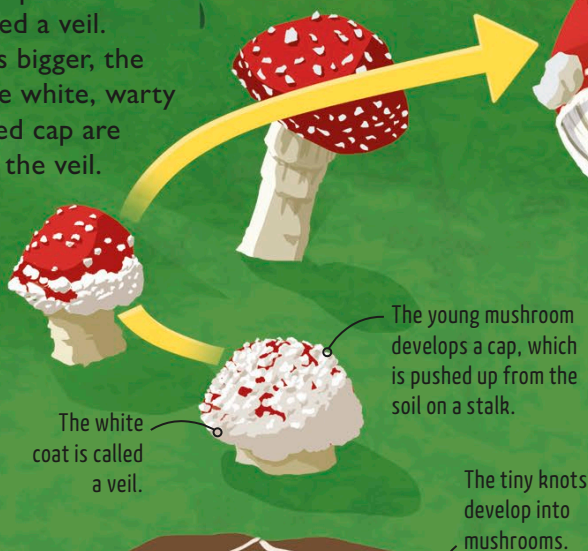


Baby mushroom

A young mushroom is protected by a special white coat called a veil. As the cap gets bigger, the veil breaks. The white, warty spots on the red cap are the remains of the veil.



Spores fall from flaps under the cap. The flaps look like fish gills.

Mat of threads

The hyphae spread out through the soil, weaving together into a mat of threads called a mycelium. The mycelium is the main part of the fungus. It feeds by taking in nutrients from dead plant and animal matter in the soil.

Knots and pinheads

When it's time to reproduce, the hyphae from different fungi knot together and form clumps in the mycelium. The knots get larger and can be seen as tiny white "pinheads" on the surface of the soil. These pinheads will become young mushrooms.

Mature mushroom

Scientists call the fully grown mushroom a fruiting body. Its cap and stalk are made of hyphae packed tightly together. Underneath the cap are papery flaps called gills. Spores line the surface of the gills.

Puffball The puffball fungus has a ball-shaped top, which is its fruiting body. It releases its spores inside the ball. When the mushroom is knocked by animals or hit by raindrops, it splits, and a cloud of spores puffs out.



Forest cleaners Fungi are waste disposal experts. As they feed, they help dead plants and animals rot and decay (decompose). Without fungi, forests would become buried by the remains of dead organisms.

